

Tutrugbu Partial ATR (Dis)harmony in Search

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The proposal uses the result of an independent search to condition the change of the other independent one in order to account for a particular aspect of the Tutrugbu ATR harmony, that is, paying attention to the vowel height combination.

keywords: Search; Tutrugbu ATR harmony

The peculiarity that the string-first vowel can have a say on the ATR harmony in Tutrugbu (a Ghana-Togo Mountain language of Kwa; McCollum et al. 2020) is examined from the perspective of (substance-free) Search (Mailhot and Reiss 2007, Dabbous et al. 2022). In the following, the description of this framework will be interspersed with the illustration of the phenomenon in question.

The plain Tutrugbu ATR harmony is shown in (1): the ATR value of the (alternating) prefix vowel(s) is determined by that of the first stem vowel (Essegbey 2009: 39, Essegbey 2019: 32).¹

(1) simplex ATR harmony (McCollum et al. 2020: 219, 220; tones omitted)²

- | | | | |
|----|----------------------|----|--------------------------------|
| a. | ɔ-da ‘CL3-copper’ | b. | ka-tɪ-ba-ba ‘CL7-NEG-FUT-come’ |
| | o-pete ‘CL3-vulture’ | | ke-ti-be-ʃe ‘CL7-NEG-FUT-grow’ |

When the respective two items in (1a) and (1b) are contrasted with each other, the prefixes are known to alternate. Since the first stem vowel is -ATR for the upper item in both columns, the prefix vowels are realized as -ATR. The +ATR realization happens for the same reason in the lower part. The ATR agreement is then formalized with a Search-based rule below:

(2) ATR agreement

Search	Change	‘Unify a vowel with the ATR value of the first ATR-specified vowel to its right.’
INR: [+syllabic]	INR ∪ {αATR}	
DIR: right		
TRM: [+syllabic, αATR]		

Search identifies if a given configuration is present. It consists of three parameters: i) the initiators (INRs) are *all* the segments which are compatible with a given feature specification; ii) the direction (DIR) instructs Search to proceed either leftward or rightward from an INR;

¹ The emphasis on the first stem vowel is due to the existence of the disharmonic stems like hɔlitsa ‘chameleon’ (Essegbey 2019: 35).

² On the surface, ɪ and ʊ are realized as ɛ and ɔ, respectively (McCollum et al. 2020: 218).

iii) the terminator (TRM) is the *first* segment whose feature composition matches with what is specified to the designated side of an INR. This operation of seeking stops when either the TRM is found or one of the two end domains is reached. In (2), every vowel is asked to look for the first vowel with an ATR value to its right. If not specified otherwise, Change only happens to those INRs which each successfully found their corresponding TRM. In (2), an INR is unified with the ATR value of the found vowel from Search. Unification, as defined in Bale et al. (2014: 245), is like union. But, when an INR contains a valued feature which is opposite to what is to be unified with, the INR remains unchanged after the application of unification. For instance, when a -ATR vowel is unified with +ATR, the vowel is still -ATR afterwards. As for a +ATR or ATR-underspecified vowel, the unification with +ATR results in the vowel with +ATR specification.

The straightforwardness of the ATR agreement, however, is complicated: if both i) the first vowel of a given string is a high vowel, and ii) there exists a prefixal non-high vowel, it is -ATR-exponents that appear (McCollum et al. 2020: 220, 221). The first two examples below all have +ATR vowel in the stem, but, instead of the predicted +ATR realization, it is -ATR realization that shows up.

(3) disharmony under the specified conditions (McCollum et al. 2020: 219, 220, 221)

- a. bu-ba-fe ‘1PL-FUT-grow’ (cf. bu-ti-fe ‘1PL-NEG-grow’)
- b. i-ti-ka-a-ba-ba-wu ‘1SG-NEG-PFV-PROG-VENTIVE-VENTIVE-climb’
- c. bu-ba-di-wu ‘1PL-FUT-ITIVE-climb’ (cf. i-di-to ‘1SG-ITIVE-cook’)

(Notice that the comparison at the end of (3a) tells us that the first person plural prefix does alternate.) The disharmony, nonetheless, is partial. When the aforementioned conditions are met, but, there remain prefixal high vowels which follow the rightmost non-high vowel, the ATR harmony applies as usual. For the portion of 1PL-FUT in (3c), the disharmony conditions are met and -ATR exponency occurs; as for the other half, the itive prefix vowel is +ATR due to the verb’s +ATR vowel.

To account for the conditioned disharmony, I let the rule -ATR-specification (4) apply before the ATR agreement (2):

(4) -ATR-specification

	Search	Change
INR-i: [+syllabic, -high]	INR-j: [+syllabic, +high]	INR-i $\sqcup$ {-ATR}
	DIR-j: left	condition: INR-j $\neq$ TRM-j ³
	TRM-j: [+syllabic]	

³ I abuse the notions INR-j and TRM-j here for them to stand for the parameters of the Search-j and the sets which contain the qualified INRs and TRMs of the Search-j.

‘Unify a non-high vowel with -ATR, if the number of high vowels which look leftward for another vowel is not equal to the number of the vowels thus found.’

The Search-i on the left column lacks DIR and TRM since it is a (semi-)context-free rule. The unification of -ATR with any non-high vowels is further qualified with the condition which is calculated through the Search-j, as shown in the middle column. By letting each high vowel look leftward for another vowel, the purpose is to check whether the string-first vowel is high or not. And the three possible scenarios are deliberated:

scenario i: there does not exist a high vowel

Since no qualified initiator can start the Search-j, neither can there be any corresponding terminator. Therefore, the cardinality of the set containing the initiators $|INR-j|$ and that of the set containing the terminators $|TRM-j|$ are both zero and the same. The if-condition is thus not met, so the Change does not take place.

scenario ii: all the high vowels are not the first vowel of the string

Because the high vowels can be the second or any of the following vowels of the string, they are always preceded by another vowel. Each initiator thus successfully finds its terminator, so the cardinality number of both sets is the same as the number of the initiators/terminators. The if-condition is thus not met, so the Change does not take place.

scenario iii: one of the high vowels is the first vowel of the string

Due to the unsuccessful Search initiated by the string-first high vowel, the cardinality of the set containing the terminators is always one less than that of the set containing the initiators. Hence, the if-condition is met, so all the non-high vowels are unified with -ATR.

With the assumption that the alternating vowels of the prefixes are not specified for the feature ATR (to be displayed with the capital letters), the derivation of bu-ba-di-wu ‘1PL-FUT-ITIVE-climb’ from (3c) is given to make concrete the foregoing discussion:

(5) a sample derivation ($\downarrow$ reads as ‘finds’ and $\Rightarrow$ as ‘becomes’)

underlying form: bU-bA-dI-wu

-ATR-specification (4)

	Search	Change
INR-i: A	INR-j: u I U	INR-i: A $\Rightarrow$ a because the condition
	$\downarrow$ $\downarrow$	$ INR-j (=3) \neq TRM-j (=2)$ is met
	TRM-j: I A	

Notice that A is not a member of INR-j for it is not +high.

intermediate form: bU-ba-dI-wu

ATR agreement (2)

Search and Change

U $\Rightarrow$ u because a is -ATR ↓ a	a $\Rightarrow$ a because -ATR of a and +ATR of u are incompatible ↓ u (not I, due to the non-specification of ATR)
I $\Rightarrow$ i because u is +ATR ↓ u	u $\Rightarrow$ u because nothing is found

surface form: bu-ba-di-wu

It is common to see that multiple searches within a rule are connected (i.e. the terminator of a search as the initiator of another). The above analysis, nonetheless, shows that it needs not to be the case. On the other hand, what remains constant is seeking for it is this property that enables us to detect the presence of a given configuration before a change may take place.

References

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